The tragic climax of the Plains Indian Wars was precipitated by the penetration of US troops and gold miners into the Black Hills of South Dakota, which was the spiritual centre of the Sioux world, from 1874. Inspired by leaders such as Crazy Horse and Sitting Bull, the warrior societies succeeded in organizing the Sioux and their Comanche and Arapaho allies for larger-scale operations to resist the US advancing cavalry.

LITTLE BIGHORN

There were probably more than 1,000 warriors involved in the famous victory over soldiers led by George Custer at the Little Bighorn River in June 1876. Although no truly reliable account of this battle exists, it appears that the Indians rapidly fired a large volume of unaimed arrows in a high trajectory to fall in a dense shower upon the US troops. They probably attacked on foot, creeping forward with maximum use of any protection afforded by the terrain and vegetation.

But even at Little Bighorn, the Indian warriors could not hold the field, being forced to retreat behind a grass fire smokescreen the following day to avoid encountering more US soldiers. Once the US was ready to devote resources ruthlessly to the Plains Indian Wars, the Indians had no answer to the destruction of their food supplies or attacks on their encampments. Crazy Horse and his assorted followers surrendered the following year, beaten by starvation and exhaustion. Sitting Bull initially took refuge in Canada, but returned to give himself up to the US authorities in 1881.

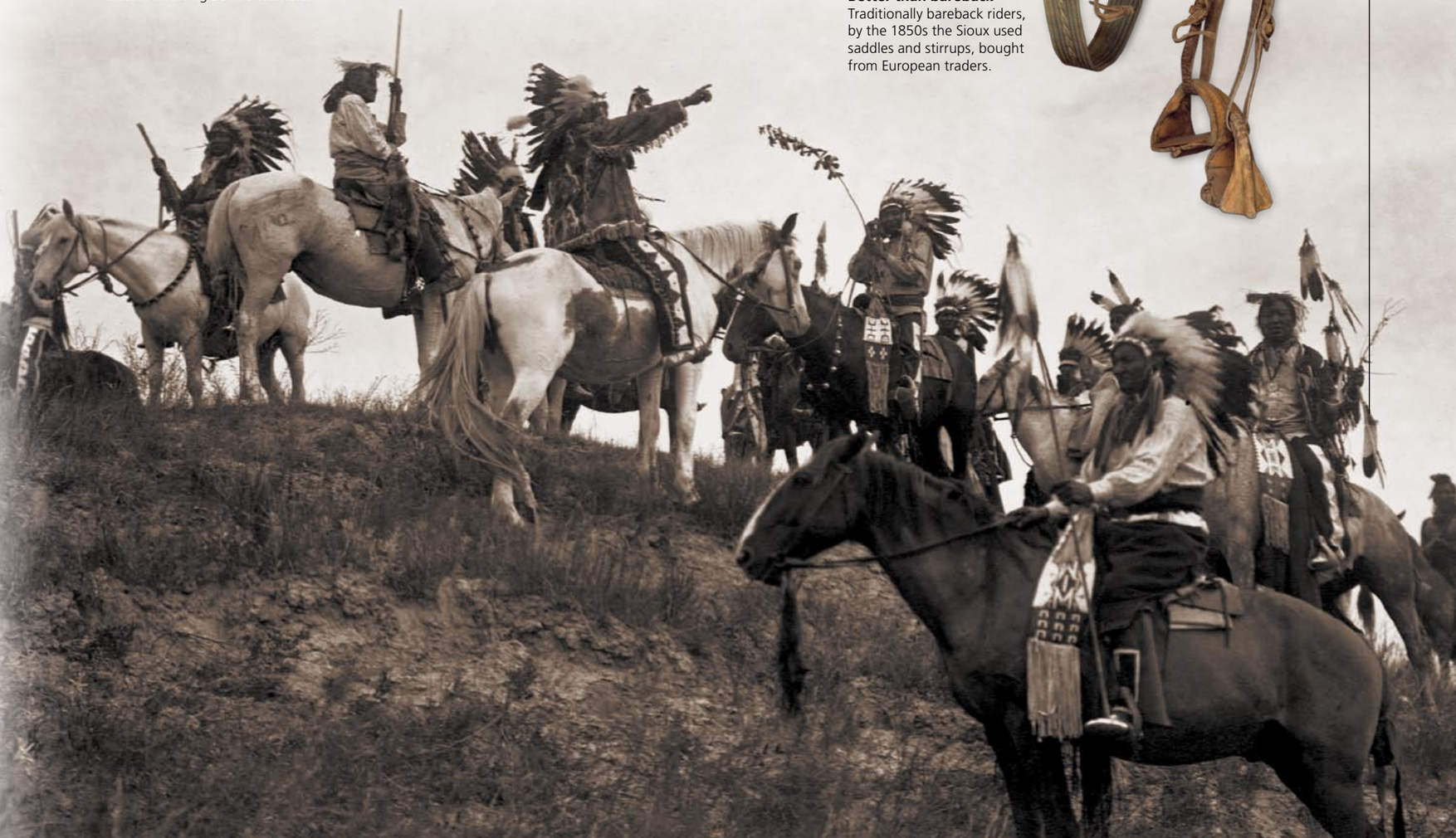
Ironically, the defeated Sioux warriors were instantly embraced by US popular culture as the noblest of savages. Sitting Bull became a celebrity, appearing briefly in Buffalo Bill's Wild West Show and making a substantial income from selling autographed pictures of himself. The reality of the Sioux's fate was, of course, grim. The Ghost Dance revival movement of 1890, ended by the infamous massacre at Wounded Knee, was a doomed last throw in a struggle the Indians knew at heart they were going to lose.



Battlegrounds and territories
As European settlers pushed westward, it was inevitable there would be conflict with Plains Indians. Many of the major battles and incidents in the American West between 1850 and 1880 involved the Sioux.



Better than bareback
Traditionally bareback riders, by the 1850s the Sioux used saddles and stirrups, bought from European traders.



Raiding party in battle dress
Sioux warfare typically consisted of raids and ambushes mounted by stealth involving 30–40 warriors.